

Chapter 122-1

The moment Liang Shi's words came out, everyone present was shocked.

Only Yang Jiani's pupils dilated for a few seconds when she heard the two words "Qi Jiao," and her struggling body suddenly froze.

Chen Mian, standing behind Liang Shi, adjusted her glasses. Anger flashed through those world-weary eyes as she stared directly at Yang Jiani.

"It's you..." Yang Jiani noticed Chen Mian standing in the back.

That ink-blue shoulder-length hair was loose and languid. She naturally carried an air of laziness about her.

She was clearly standing together with everyone else, yet seemed like a person from a different world.

Chen Mian curved her lips in a mocking smile, "You still remember me."

Yang Jiani repeated herself haltingly several times, but it was just those same two words over and over.

—It's you.

Chen Mian's gaze gradually turned cold, as if she were looking at a dead person.

A moment later, Yang Jiani was like a maddened wild beast, struggling again, even more violently than before.

Her eyes were bloodshot red. The cold metal handcuffs were stained with her blood, silver turning to crimson, yet she didn't notice at all. Her hair fell scattered on both sides of her face as she let out a voice-cracking roar at the two of them.

The sound was so loud that the two police officers holding her instinctively frowned. They tried their best to press down on her shoulders but were still injured by her constant struggling.

The police officers were strong enough, but because Yang Jiani was in a completely maddened state right now, she didn't care about her own body at all—even injuries could be ignored.

Like a cornered beast desperately trying to break through its cage.

As if her enemies were outside the cage.

After that roar, Yang Jiani cursed loudly with her voice-cracked, broken-gong voice, "All of you people! Just go die!"

She had originally been an opera performer with a beautiful voice. When she spoke normally, it naturally carried a clarity to it.

Like spring stream water flowing clearly over rocks.

But now her voice was completely damaged. It was rare to see someone damage their vocal cords purely from screaming in rage—it showed just how desperate and furious she was.

Yang Jiani had lost all her former grace. She spat in the direction of Chen Mian and Liang Shi. Fortunately, the two dodged in time.

That glob of spit landed on the wall.

It was tinged with blood.

Yang Jiani's tears were murky, mixed with her deathly pale makeup.

She looked like a midnight ghost, somewhat terrifying.

"It's all because of you people!" Yang Jiani screamed at the top of her lungs. "Chen Mian! You're the one who should have died! It's you!"

"Why did my Jiaojiao have to die! You go die! Why didn't you go with her! It's all your fault! You killed my Jiaojiao!" As Yang Jiani screamed, she collapsed to her knees from exhaustion.

Liang Shi glanced at Chen Mian, only to see Chen Mian staring at Yang Jiani expressionlessly.

But her slightly trembling body betrayed her emotions.

Chen Mian swallowed, her slender neck radiating a sickly, dazzling white under the cold sunlight.

Chen Mian's voice was very cold, like shards of ice in the depths of winter¹, transforming into a sharp knife stabbing into one's heart. "Qi Jiao died because of you."

Chen Mian said, "Because of your excessive control and morbid possessiveness, you made her life neither human nor ghost². That's why she went to die."

"It was you." Chen Mian said, "You gave her life, yet you also strangled her soul."

Chen Mian's tears suddenly fell through the air—without any crying, a single crystalline tear simply dropped.

She gave people the feeling of being cold and distant, as if she wouldn't be moved by anything in this world.

But when Qi Jiao was mentioned, she would briefly reveal human characteristics.

Tenderness, anger, warmth.

Chen Mian's icy voice echoed faintly, "You're the one who should have died, Yang Jiani."

"Because you didn't die." Chen Mian continued, "And Qi Jiao didn't want you to die either—that's why she went to die."

Yang Jiani was stunned by her words, her struggling movements stopping. The leader nearby saw this and immediately directed people to drag Yang Jiani away from the crime scene.

Chen Mian turned around, no longer facing the crowd.

The place briefly fell into silence.

This confrontation left everyone completely confused, not understanding what they were talking about at all.

The person in charge of this case was Officer Sun from the Criminal Investigation Brigade. He quickly pulled himself out of that heart-shaking confrontation, gathered his thoughts, and asked Liang Shi, "What did you say just now? What else do you want to report?"

Liang Shi repeated her earlier words, "I said, what I want to report is that Yang Jiani killed her daughter Qi Jiao."

Officer Sun said, "The report we received from you earlier was about this. Currently, the victim is being emergency rescued at the hospital. The hospital sent word that she needs a blood transfusion but hasn't passed away yet."

"No." Liang Shi shook her head lightly.

She glanced in the direction Yang Jiani had been taken and said resoundingly, "The person being rescued at the hospital is Gu Xingyue, not Qi Jiao."

Liang Shi's next words overturned everyone present's understanding.

She said, "Yang Jiani's attack on Gu Xingyue was intentional harm—attempted murder. But her real daughter Qi Jiao died thirteen years ago."

Shortly after Qi Jiao jumped from the building, she pushed Qi Jiao, who had just returned from the gates of hell, back in again.

Footnotes:

¹ **Depths of winter (三九寒天):** Refers to the "San Jiu" period, the coldest days of winter in the Chinese calendar. "San Jiu" literally means "three nines," referring to the third nine-day period after the Winter Solstice, traditionally considered the coldest time of year.

² **Neither human nor ghost (人不人鬼不鬼):** A Chinese expression describing a miserable existence where someone is barely living—not quite alive like a human, not quite dead like a ghost. It describes an unbearable state of living.

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Yang Jiani was arrested on suspicion of intentional harm and malicious murder.

This incident brought up matters concerning Qi Jiao from many years ago, and along with it, the old affairs of the Angel Orphanage were also dragged out.

This was an enormous matter that was very difficult to investigate thoroughly.

As for what Gu Xingyue meant by serial murder—she was referring to Yang Jiani first killing Qi Xiangui, then attacking Gu Xingyue.

On the day Gu Xingyue reported to the police, Qi Xiangui's body had already been lying in the cold basement for two days.

Moreover, his death was brutal, with nearly twenty or more wounds on his body.

According to the forensic examination, the fatal wound was to the head, and the cause of death was being struck by a blunt object.

Yang Jiani's murder weapon was a wrench.

Liang Shi knew very little about the details of all this. That day, she went to the police station with Chen Mian. As the person who reported the case, she cooperated with the police investigation—just giving her statement took over two hours.

Chen Mian knew even less, but she talked about matters from Qi Jiao's middle school days.

Because of her confrontation and dispute with Yang Jiani at the Qi residence's entrance, no one would believe there was nothing between them.

Chen Mian also told everything she knew, but unfortunately she knew too little, so the information she provided wasn't of much use.

The key to the matter still lay with Gu Xingyue, who was currently lying in the ICU.

This day was a long one.

For Liang Shi, it was also just one of the most ordinary days in her life.

She left the crew whose filming had been suspended, received Gu Xingyue's call in a confused daze, and out of trust in Gu Xingyue, reported to the police without hesitation.

After reporting, she cooperated with the police investigation and provided as much evidence as possible.

Even though Gu Xingyue had said before that if it involved the Angel Orphanage, she wouldn't do it.

But for some reason, she suddenly changed sides.

When Liang Shi was providing evidence, she also truthfully told them about the Angel Orphanage matters, including Gu Zhaoyuan and Gu Yingbo.

It was only when she called to contact Gu Zhaoyuan that she learned Director Gu Yingbo had passed away two days ago.

Exactly on the day Qi Xiangui was killed by Yang Jiani.

Liang Shi couldn't hide her surprise in the police station and asked in a low voice about Gu Yingbo's cause of death.

Gu Zhaoyuan said he had a nightmare, and after waking up, he kept calling out "Xingyue, Xingyue." After calling out a few times, he jumped from the second floor. His body was already weak, and combined with his advanced age, he died on the spot.

Gu Zhaoyuan was in the process of arranging his funeral. After hearing all this, Liang Shi could only offer her condolences.

She then asked, "Does Gu Xingyue know about this?"

Gu Zhaoyuan paused, then said in a deep voice, "She knows."

The letter that Liang Shi had passed on to Gu Zhaoyuan contained a phone number that Gu Xingyue had left for Gu Zhaoyuan, written in their unique way of communicating.

After Gu Zhaoyuan received it, he didn't dare contact Gu Xingyue at first, afraid that she would be discovered or bullied because of him, since Liang Shi had said her current situation wasn't good.

But just a few days later, that thing happened to Gu Yingbo.

Gu Zhaoyuan cried bitterly late at night and couldn't help but send Gu Xingyue a message: [Dad died. If possible, could you come see him? Xingyue.]

That message received no response, as if it had sunk into the ocean like a stone.

Gu Zhaoyuan gave up hope after that. These past few days, he had been like a walking corpse, numbly handling the nursing home's affairs. Fortunately, there were still some children around to help, otherwise he would have collapsed.

After hearing this, Liang Shi told him to hold on a bit longer—Gu Xingyue would go back.

She guessed that Gu Xingyue's sudden action was related to Gu Yingbo's death. And now Gu Yingbo hadn't been cremated yet, nor had a funeral been held.

Liang Shi said, "Wait a little longer. Xingyue should want to see Director Gu one last time."

"It won't work." Gu Zhaoyuan said, "The smell of the corpse is too strong, and since he fell from a building, his appearance in death is too awful. I don't want Xingyue to see her father like that. I don't think Father would want that either."

Gu Zhaoyuan paused, "I'll cremate Father's body first, and when Xingyue comes, we'll hold the funeral then."

Liang Shi sighed softly, "That works too."

With just a few sentences, a person's entire life was thus concluded.

After calling Gu Zhaoyuan, Liang Shi requested to wait until Gu Xingyue woke up before mentioning the orphanage matters. The first thing to be dealt with was definitely Yang Jiani's serial murder case.

Serial murder—those four characters sounded extremely cruel just hearing them.

But the most terrifying part was that after Qi Xiangui was killed with a blunt object, there were over twenty knife wounds on the body, caused by a household fruit knife.

And he was killed after drinking alcohol.

The methods were extremely brutal.

When Liang Shi and Chen Mian heard about this method of killing at the police station, they were horrified. Just as the body was being transported back to the Criminal Investigation Unit, a forensic examiner outside lifted the white cloth to take a look.

They saw it too.

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The scene was so bloody it made people want to vomit.

The body that had been lying in the cold basement for two days emitted a thick stench of decay—the kind that would immediately attract a swarm of flies if left out in summer. His clothes were tattered, especially the lower half of his body. His genitals had been physically castrated, blood had congealed on his body, and there were at least two or three knife wounds on his thighs.

Even the forensic examiner with many years of experience was shocked. He put down the white cloth and frowned, "Did the bureau get a perverted murder case?"

A junior officer who knew a bit of the inside story said, "No, it's a husband-killing case."

"Seriously?" The forensic examiner was astonished. "This brutal?"

"Not only that, she also killed her daughters." The junior officer said, "Biological daughter, adopted daughter—killed them all."

The forensic examiner: "....."

That forensic examiner stood there in a daze. After the cart pushing the body had gone far away, he muttered, "She must be mentally ill, right?"

Liang Shi wasn't far away. After hearing his mutter, she replied in her heart: "You couldn't do something like this without being mentally ill."

All in all, this incident caused a tremendous shock to the Municipal Public Security Bureau as well.

It wasn't a perverted murder case, yet a perverted murderer had appeared, and it also dragged up old matters from many years ago.

The Municipal Public Security Bureau classified it as a malicious homicide incident and specially formed a task force to investigate the case.

Liang Shi stayed at the police station until evening before leaving. She and Chen Mian stood at the entrance of the police station.

Both of them were starving, yet neither had any appetite to eat.

For Liang Shi, it was because she had been nauseated by seeing Qi Xiangui's body during the day—she had no appetite at all.

As for Chen Mian...

It was probably because she was thinking of Qi Jiao.

It was close to the fifteenth of the lunar month¹, and the moon in the sky was like a jade disc, shrouded in a layer of hazy, dim gauze.

The two stood side by side, and for a moment, neither spoke.

Chen Mian gazed at the moon in the sky. After a long while, she finally said in an obscure voice, "Hungry?"

Liang Shi shook her head.

Chen Mian said to herself, "Let me buy you a drink."

Liang Shi: "....."

Footnotes:

¹ **Fifteenth of the lunar month:** In the Chinese lunar calendar, the fifteenth day of each month is when the moon is at its fullest. This is why the moon is described as being like a "jade disc"—round and luminous.

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Liang Shi felt she needed to get drunk.

The impact of what she encountered during the day was too great. But the two of them first went to the hospital to see Gu Xingyue.

However, because Gu Xingyue was involved in a malicious murder case, she had become a key protected person by both the Public Security Bureau and the hospital to prevent anyone from causing her secondary harm.

The two went to the hospital only to return empty-handed.

Other than passively waiting for results, there was nothing they could do.

On the way leaving the hospital, Chen Mian said, "She really surprised me."

Liang Shi nodded, "I didn't expect her to be this ruthless."

"If Qi Jiao also had..." Chen Mian paused mid-sentence and rejected her own statement, "No, there are no ifs."

Qi Jiao was Qi Jiao.

She could never do something like this.

Because those were her biological parents.

But for Gu Xingyue, it was different—they were just two demons.

People who had nothing to do with her.

Gu Xingyue resisting Yang Jiani was like a prisoner resisting a warden, without any bonds of familial affection or blood.

She might even feel a faint sense of pleasure after getting her revenge. But for Qi Jiao, it wouldn't be like that.

If Qi Jiao had done this, for the rest of her life, she would frequently dream about it.

She would forever live in self-blame and guilt.

It was hard to say which was better, but in the end, the one who would suffer would always be Qi Jiao.

When the conversation turned to Qi Jiao, the atmosphere suddenly became heavy.

For a moment, neither of them spoke.

Liang Shi sat in Chen Mian's passenger seat. Her brain, which had been busy all day, finally stole a moment of peace. She took out her phone and sent a message to Xu Qingzhu: [Are you home?]

Xu Qingzhu replied instantly: [Mm.]

Liang Shi told her: [The crew has suspended filming.]

Xu Qingzhu: [Because of Shu Yi?]

Liang Shi: [Yes.]

Shu Yi's incident had been on the trending list for two days, so Xu Qingzhu naturally knew about it.

But she hadn't known what the "Mo Guang" crew was planning to do about it. Liang Shi had still been waiting at the hotel for the outcome last night.

Now the outcome was out, and it was evening again.

Xu Qingzhu sent a voice message: "Are you coming home tonight then?"

Liang Shi replied: [I am, but I'm going to drink first.]

Xu Qingzhu: [.....]

Before she could ask, Liang Shi added: [With Chen Mian. She said she wants to treat me to drinks.]

Xu Qingzhu: [.....]

Liang Shi: [I'll try to stay sober when I come home. Go to bed early.]

Xu Qingzhu: [.....]

Three ellipses in a row—even someone as oblivious as Liang Shi understood that Xu Qingzhu had something she wanted to say.

Liang Shi asked: [What's wrong?]

Xu Qingzhu didn't reply for a long time.

Liang Shi vaguely felt that Xu Qingzhu was angry, but she really didn't want to go home after experiencing such huge emotional turmoil, afraid of bringing her bad mood to Xu Qingzhu.

Even though Xu Qingzhu had said: Liang Shi, you can be yourself.

But that didn't mean she should make Xu Qingzhu bear her bad emotions.

She just needed to get drunk, sleep it off, and calm her feelings.

She hoped Xu Qingzhu would be happy every day.

Liang Shi sent another message to Xu Qingzhu: [Don't go silent on me.]

Xu Qingzhu still didn't reply.

Liang Shi glanced at Chen Mian in the car. Chen Mian was turning the steering wheel to make a turn, her lips pressed tightly together, looking unapproachable.

Liang Shi's lips parted slightly, and Chen Mian said, "Want to go home?"

Liang Shi: "....."

For a moment, she didn't know whether to say yes or no.

She had already agreed to go with Chen Mian. Wouldn't it be bad to back out now?

But not going home after the crew suspended filming and instead going out drinking with Chen Mian—that seemed like something that would make Xu Qingzhu angry.

Now Xu Qingzhu wasn't even replying to messages.

If she had taken the initiative and seized control of the conversation earlier, she wouldn't be in such a difficult position now.¹

She stared at Chen Mian for a few seconds. That "mm" she was about to say suddenly changed direction and became "How could that be?"

Chen Mian said, "I thought as soon as your girlfriend urged you, you'd want to go home."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi lowered her head and sent another message to Xu Qingzhu: [Don't be angry. I won't get drunk.]

Her coaxing was exceptionally stiff.

But this was already the result of what Liang Shi had learned.

Footnotes:

¹ **Difficult position (騎虎難下):** A Chinese idiom literally meaning "riding a tiger and finding it hard to dismount." It describes being in a situation where it's difficult to either continue or stop—being stuck in an awkward predicament of one's own making.

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After sending the message to Xu Qingzhu, Liang Shi said to Chen Mian very seriously, "She's not my girlfriend."

Chen Mian's car had just stopped by the roadside. Only the dim yellow light remained inside the car. Liang Shi's voice was gentle, carrying a hint of tenderness, "I'm married."

Chen Mian paused slightly. Those cold eyes flickered for a moment, then she curved her lips into a smile, "Congratulations."

"I'll introduce you two someday." Liang Shi said, "She knows about you."

This surprised Chen Mian.

Liang Shi said, "She also knows about Qi Jiao."

At the mention of Qi Jiao, Chen Mian's attitude shifted, though her voice remained cold.

She said, "Then let's meet sometime."

After saying this, she tossed the car keys into her pocket, and her thin figure walked toward the bar.

This street was noisy and bustling, with signs flashing in all colors of light.

Chen Mian's figure mingled among the crowd. Those strange lights shone on her ink-blue hair, making her entire being seem lonely and desolate.

Out of place with this world.

Liang Shi stared at her back, thought for two seconds, then followed.

She suddenly had an intuition—Chen Mian was using this way to remember Qi Jiao.

Because Qi Jiao had died, but no one knew.

There was no one around her who could talk about Qi Jiao with her.

So Chen Mian would treat everyone who knew about Qi Jiao with tolerance.

Simply because they still remembered Qi Jiao, and could help her remember—that Qi Jiao had once existed.

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It was only after Liang Shi walked into the bar that she received Xu Qingzhu's reply.

Xu Qingzhu's cool, clear voice came through the speaker, hard to hear clearly in the noisy environment.

Liang Shi turned the volume up to maximum, then held the phone to her ear, covering one ear with her hand.

That voice carried a hint of helplessness, "Send me the address. I'll come find you in a bit."

Liang Shi directly sent her the location.

Xu Qingzhu sent another voice message: "I'm not angry. You're just drinking."

Liang Shi: [.....]

Perhaps because of a guilty conscience, even after hearing Xu Qingzhu say this, Liang Shi still felt that Xu Qingzhu was angry.

Liang Shi thought for a moment: [How about I wait until you arrive before drinking?]

This time Xu Qingzhu was truly exasperated. Her words contained a hint of laughter: "Is that really necessary? If people heard, they'd say you're henpecked."¹

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi sent her a voice message in the noisy bar, lips close to the microphone.

Her voice was mixed with the noisy background, her gentle voice carrying a hint of proud stubbornness, "Henpecked it is then. It's not some serious disease."

After sending it, taking advantage of the fact that no one was paying attention to her, she sent another: "As long as you're not angry, who cares what others think."

Xu Qingzhu: [.....]

The heavy metal music in the bar was giving people headaches. Men and women on the dance floor were swaying their bodies.

This was a rather open bar. Quite a few people were carrying drinks to chat people up, kissing passionately right at the bar counter.

Everyone was used to it.

Though there weren't too many such people—most just handed over a business card, or directly linked arms and went to get a room next door.

Right next door was a large hotel.

Liang Shi had never been to a place like this. Seeing two people kissing inseparably at the bar counter, she said to Chen Mian in surprise, "This is too uninhibited. At least go to a hotel."

She didn't quite understand why Chen Mian would like coming to a place like this.

She had thought that a melancholic artist like Chen Mian would go to a quiet bar if she went to one at all—playing some artistic songs, everyone sitting there watching the bartender show off mixing techniques.

Liang Shi thought this way, and asked as much.

After two drinks, her body warmed up, and the fatigue finally began to dissipate somewhat.

The only thing the two of them had in common was Qi Jiao.

Because they were both reminiscing about Qi Jiao, they could sit here drinking together.

Chen Mian's sickly pale fingers held a glass of "Flaming Rose." The red liquid swayed gently in the transparent glass as her eyes looked through the glass at the lights, and at this world.

The liquor flowed past her lips and tongue, down her throat, swallowed into her stomach.

Chen Mian curved her lips in a slight smile, "Don't you think this is the best place to observe people?"

"Human nature is vile." Chen Mian's alcohol-soaked voice grew even colder. "They're cold, selfish—this is the place where they release themselves."

Chen Mian looked at the women kissing in the distance. "Don't you think that being able to go into heat anytime, anywhere, able to couple without any love—they're just like animals? Because no one cares, they brazenly expose their vileness, their lust."

"Humans always think themselves noble, but in truth are the lowest of all."

After Chen Mian finished speaking, she downed the rest of her drink in one gulp. The transparent glass landed on the dark marble.

When Liang Shi looked again at the pair of women kissing in the distance, they had already linked arms and left.

They had probably tested each other's kissing skills and were now contentedly going to get a room at the hotel next door.

Here, there was quick sex, vulgar conversations, overlapping desires, decadent crowds.

People seemed to have no humanity, all returning to their true nature, returning to bodily desires.

Or rather, coming here in itself was about breaking free from morality and restraint.

Footnotes:

¹ **Henpecked (妻管嚴):** A Chinese term literally meaning "strictly controlled by one's wife." It describes a husband who is completely obedient to his wife, similar to the English term "whipped" or "henpecked." Despite the seemingly negative connotation, in modern usage it's often used lightheartedly.

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Liang Shi pondered Chen Mian's words, and after a moment, also finished the drink in her glass.

This drink looked beautiful, like a vast ocean, but the instant she drank it, she nearly choked.

Very strong.

This glass of "Starry Waves" was recommended by Chen Mian. From the way Chen Mian ordered, you could tell she came to this bar often.

After a few drinks, Liang Shi suddenly asked, "Have you ever tried it?"

Chen Mian raised an eyebrow, "What?"

"Mingling among them." Liang Shi said.

Chen Mian shook her head, "I look down on them."

"I like watching the parade of a hundred demons."¹ Chen Mian chuckled softly, "That doesn't mean I have to mingle among the demons."

Liang Shi paused before saying, "Your words are so profound."

Chen Mian shrugged, "Your emotional intelligence is really high."

Liang Shi: "....."

Chen Mian said, "Everyone else thinks I'm crazy."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi's face made her quite the coveted existence in this bar. In the time it took to drink five glasses, seven or eight people came over wanting to have a drink with her, and also wanting to take her to the hotel next door.

Chen Mian would retreat whenever someone came over, pretending not to know this person, watching at her leisure as Liang Shi dealt with these people.

Liang Shi explained over and over again, "I have a family, I have a wife, not interested."

Later, she became impatient and just used two words: "Go away."

It wasn't until the eighth person left that Liang Shi asked Chen Mian, "Are you using me as an observation specimen?"

"Not at all." Chen Mian said, "I just find it amusing."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi was speechless, but before she could even finish being speechless, another one came, "Hey beautiful, wanna go?"

"No." Liang Shi looked at her. The other person was fairly pretty, mainly because her chest was big—at first glance, she looked like she'd walked out of a manga.

You couldn't even see her neck or waist.

This figure was quite the display for Liang Shi.

Mainly because she stood so close, she was practically in Liang Shi's face.

Liang Shi held up her glass and pushed her away, "I have a wife, not interested."

The other person shrugged her shoulders, those two soft mounds still jiggling—it was clearly a deliberate show. She probably knew this was her advantage and could make good use of it.

But Liang Shi felt no ripple of emotion inside. She was even starting to want to go home.

Why on earth had she been foolish enough to come here with Chen Mian?

Chen Mian was here to observe humans, but what about her?

Was she here to endure a tribulation?²

Liang Shi was mentally exhausted. She wanted to go home, wanted to lie in bed, wanted to...

Hold her wife and sleep.

When this thought emerged, she was even startled herself.

It was probably because she had said "I have a family, I have a wife" so many times tonight that she herself had started to believe it was true.

And it felt very natural.

The rejected woman walked away with her cleavage, giving a soft huff as she left, looking at Liang Shi with disdain, "Doesn't know quality when she sees it."

Liang Shi: "....."

She had her own!

Liang Shi sat there helplessly, planning to finish her drink and leave.

Just as she was taking the last sip, a cool, clear voice came from beside her, "Beautiful, want a drink?"

Liang Shi: "?"

Liang Shi answered without thinking, "No—"

Before the second word could come out, she turned her head and saw Xu Qingzhu. The words she was about to say were swallowed back down.

They hadn't seen each other for several days. Her sudden appearance in front of her felt just a little bit unfamiliar.

Xu Qingzhu was wearing a light blue long dress with a white casual blazer over it, her long hair hanging down casually.

When this face appeared in the bar, it once again set off a wave of people trying to chat her up.

But Liang Shi just stared straight at her.

The drinks Chen Mian had recommended to Liang Shi all had a strong delayed effect. At this moment, the eyes staring at Xu Qingzhu were misty, those light brown pupils reflecting the lights, and also Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu smiled lightly, "Not drinking anymore?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Xu Qingzhu had only casually teased her, yet Liang Shi's ears had already turned red.

It was probably because she hadn't heard Xu Qingzhu speak in so long. Liang Shi stammered, "If you want to drink, I'll have another glass with you."

Her tone was full of indulgence and pampering.

Footnotes:

¹ **Parade of a hundred demons (百鬼夜行):** A concept from Japanese and Chinese folklore referring to a supernatural parade of demons, spirits, and yokai that occurs at night. Here, Chen Mian uses it metaphorically to describe the decadent crowd in the bar—she enjoys observing them as if they were demons on display, but doesn't want to become one of them.

² **Endure a tribulation (渡劫):** A concept from Chinese cultivation novels and Daoist beliefs. Tribulations are trials or ordeals that cultivators must endure to advance to higher levels of power. Here, Liang Shi uses it humorously to describe her suffering from being constantly hit on at the bar.

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Xu Qingzhu nodded, "Shall we go home to drink? I drove, so I need to take you back."

Liang Shi was about to get up and responded with an "okay."

Before she could stand up, someone came over to chat her up, "Beautiful miss, may I invite you for a drink?"

The person who came was a short-haired girl. Her face was decent, but her height was average—even a bit shorter than Xu Qingzhu.

Who knew where her confidence came from.

Before Xu Qingzhu could speak, Liang Shi restrained all traces of a smile and said coldly, "No."

The other person frowned, "What's your problem? I'm not asking to drink with you."

Liang Shi: "....."

"You drinking with my wife—that's not happening." Having drunk a bit too much, her speech was very matter-of-fact, sounding somewhat amusing.

Liang Shi's tone was so serious that the girl was stunned for a moment, then said, "I just want to have a drink with your wife, it's not like I'm sleeping with her.."

Before the girl could finish speaking, Liang Shi turned and grabbed the drink the bartender had just made for Chen Mian. It seemed to be called "Forest Sprite"—forest green in color.

The glass was new; Chen Mian hadn't drunk from it yet.

Liang Shi picked it up and took a sip, then reached out and tugged at Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu's knees went soft, and she sat directly on her lap.

The bar was noisy and chaotic, but when Liang Shi stared at Xu Qingzhu, it was as if the world had been put on pause, all the noise isolated outside the two of them.

Liang Shi placed one hand on the back of Xu Qingzhu's neck, closed her eyes, and kissed her.

All the alcohol was transferred over.

This kiss was particularly domineering.

Liang Shi's other hand tightly embraced Xu Qingzhu's waist as the liquor was shared between them.

When the kiss ended, Liang Shi pressed Xu Qingzhu's face into her embrace, not letting anyone see.

The hot breath from Xu Qingzhu's breathing was all released onto her body through the clothes, making Liang Shi's heart race with restless thoughts.

But Liang Shi looked at the person who had come to chat them up and said coldly, "My wife doesn't drink with other people. She only drinks with me."

Xu Qingzhu, nestled in her arms, laughed softly, her body trembling with laughter.

Liang Shi pinched her waist, as if in punishment.

The girl who had come to chat them up was shocked and eventually left awkwardly.

Liang Shi couldn't stay in this place any longer. She took another sip of alcohol to calm her restlessness, said goodbye to Chen Mian, and left with Xu Qingzhu.

The originally slender and tall-looking Xu Qingzhu, standing beside the over-170-centimeter Liang Shi, appeared exceptionally well-matched.

They walked all the way to the car.

Liang Shi first opened the driver's side door for Xu Qingzhu, but Xu Qingzhu closed the door and leaned against it with a smile, "Teacher Liang, how much did you drink this time?"

Liang Shi: "....."

She mumbled, "Five glasses."

"Why does it feel like you drank fifty?" Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi shook her head, "I didn't."

"Then why would you think I can still drive?" Xu Qingzhu asked her, "What were you doing just now?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Both of them were too good-looking, and passersby would cast curious glances their way.

Especially those sizing up Xu Qingzhu.

Liang Shi stood in front of Xu Qingzhu, "You're too beautiful."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She found it amusing and raised an eyebrow, "So?"

"I don't want others to look at you." Liang Shi said, "I don't want others to ask you for drinks."

Her tone was very serious, just like a primary school student answering questions in class.

But Xu Qingzhu provoked her, "What if others insist?"

"Better to drink with me instead." Liang Shi moved closer to her, bending down to approach. Her teeth landed on Xu Qingzhu's collarbone, biting gently, her hot breath released entirely on her neck, "I'll feed Teacher Xu the alcohol."

"How will you feed me?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi pressed her lips together, looked around—there was almost no one nearby—and leaned in to kiss her.

Liang Shi cushioned her hand behind Xu Qingzhu's head, afraid she might bump it.

But because they were outside, Liang Shi didn't go too far.

She only gave a light kiss before separating.

Xu Qingzhu turned her face to the side and said helplessly, "You've rubbed off all my lipstick."

Liang Shi: "...Just think of it as you doing my makeup."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

She felt like Liang Shi, who had been with the crew for a while, seemed to have changed.

But she didn't probe further.

Xu Qingzhu had also drunk alcohol and couldn't drive, so they could only call for a designated driver.¹

Footnotes:

¹ **Designated driver service (代駕):** In China, there are professional designated driver services where you can hire someone to drive your car home for you if you've been drinking. This is different from a taxi—the driver comes to you and drives your own vehicle while you sit as a passenger, then leaves after dropping you off.

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After ordering a designated driver, the two of them went to sit in the back seat of the car to wait.

Xu Qingzhu asked her why she was with Chen Mian. Liang Shi paused for a moment, then said in a low voice, "Qi Xiangui is dead."

Xu Qingzhu was shocked, "What?"

Liang Shi pressed Xu Qingzhu's head onto her shoulder, finding a point of support for herself as well. Her face lightly brushed against the tips of Xu Qingzhu's hair, catching a faint orange fragrance.

"Yang Jiani killed Qi Xiangui, then tried to kill Gu Xingyue. She was arrested today." Liang Shi explained the situation concisely. "Gu Xingyue's injuries are too severe. She's still in the hospital."

Xu Qingzhu didn't know what to say for a moment.

The car fell quiet.

Liang Shi's fingers played with Xu Qingzhu's hair. After a long while, Xu Qingzhu finally said, "Qi Jiao should have a very warm family in her next life."

Liang Shi responded with an "mm," "Yeah."

Her voice was low and subdued. After a while, she suddenly said to Xu Qingzhu, "In my memories, she was just like a little angel. She was also beautiful, like a little princess—gentle and wonderful. I feel like if I had a daughter like that, I would be happy to death."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

"So she's a little angel. What am I?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi paused, her mind going blank.

"Teacher Liang." Xu Qingzhu said, "You're praising another girl like this in front of me. Do you really think I won't get angry?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"No." Liang Shi said, "I... I was just telling you about this."

Xu Qingzhu's head dropped down. Though she leaned closer to Liang Shi, burying her head in her embrace, her voice was muffled and didn't sound happy at all. "I know you and Qi Jiao were close. Sister Qi Jiao was so good to you. The two of you kept each other warm in the darkness together, and she protected you. It's perfectly normal that you would like her."

Liang Shi: "....."

These words sounded heartbreaking.

But the tone was strangely familiar.

Xu Qingzhu said, "If Qi Jiao hadn't died, you would definitely have married Qi Jiao, right? The two of you have a past that no one else knows about. You could heal each other, warm each other."

"No." Liang Shi hurriedly explained, "We weren't that kind of..."

"You'll definitely say that it wasn't that kind of feeling between you two, but that's only because Sister Qi Jiao died." Xu Qingzhu's body was still trembling, as if she was crying. "How could a living person ever compare to a dead one?"

Liang Shi completely panicked. With the alcohol going to her head, she didn't know what to do. "Xu Qingzhu... I've never thought that way."

Liang Shi said, "Qi Jiao really was like a sister to me. We do have a past that others don't know about, but now you know, don't you? The fact that I'm willing to tell you means..."

Xu Qingzhu's body was trembling too violently. Worried that she was crying, Liang Shi propped her whole body up, only to see a pair of eyes curved in a smile.

Liang Shi: "....."

For a moment, she didn't know what to say.

Xu Qingzhu's smile grew even wider. She pinched Liang Shi's face, "You're so cute."

Liang Shi: "....."

She was so angry she secretly gritted her teeth, but then Xu Qingzhu laughed, "It's not like only you have memories with an older sister. Who doesn't have some memories with a beautiful older sister?"

Hearing this, Liang Shi suddenly pressed her down onto the car seat.

Xu Qingzhu only felt the world spinning around her, but there was still a hand cushioning the back of her head.

Liang Shi leaned close to her ear and said indignantly, "You're not allowed to like that beautiful older sister of yours."
